

# Volume 1 • Issue 1

Promulgation of CONSTITUTION.md@v1.0.0

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Inaugural

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Communiqué PBC

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## §A Promulgation

This issue promulgates **CONSTITUTION.md@v1.0.0** as the design constitution of the reference implementation of the Commons protocol. The constitution is structured in five sections — Substrate, Artifact, Commons, Open-protocol commitments, and Amendment.

The constitution does not bind the protocol substrate. The protocol substrate is governed by voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md and the specifications under voter-protocol/specs/. The constitution does not bind peer implementations of the protocol; peers publish their own design constitutions. The constitution binds the reference implementation maintained by Communiqué PBC.

Adoption is effective on this issue's date.

## §B Editorial note: voice register supersession

Prior to this issue, the design voice of the reference implementation was documented in `docs/design/voice.md` under the heading "*Direct. Specific. Institutional.*" Effective with the publication of this issue, that doctrine is **superseded** by the GOV.UK plain-English register described in §3.3 of the constitution.

The prior register served the reference implementation through pre-launch development. The supersession is recorded honestly: it was not a refinement but a register reset. The cypherpunk-direct register over-rewarded specificity at the expense of accessibility. The plain-English register accepts a small loss of precision for a substantial gain in legibility across the reader populations the public record must serve — civic staffers, citizens, designers, auditors, and future maintainers reading at a thirty-year horizon.

The prior `voice.md` is retained in the repository with status SUPERSEDED and is not deleted. References from current code that adopt the prior register are migrated through Phase 3 of the realignment work, which closed 2026-05-05. Where any conflict arises between the constitution and the superseded `voice.md`, the constitution governs.

## §C Errata policy

Errata of fact that do not change meaning — typos, formatting, broken links — are corrected by the maintainer and recorded in the next issue's errata block, without amendment.

Substantive change to the constitution is amendment, governed by §5 of the constitution: at least two reviewers in writing, including at least one independent security researcher or peer-implementation operator, with the supermajority threshold rising as peer implementations adopt the protocol substrate.

Errata to this issue, or amendments to the constitution that arise after this issue's publication, are appended below with their own hash, the proposal hash that admitted them, and the date. The masthead's hash manifest preserves the chain in chronological

order. The first-publication hash of each source document is canonical and is not retroactively changed.

## §D Cadence

Issues of the public record are published as material developments warrant. There is no fixed cadence. The expected occasions for a new issue are:

- adoption of an amendment to the constitution

- promulgation of a new normative artifact (a new specification module, a new set of design primitives that supersedes a prior set)

- recording of a constitutional moment (the first peer implementation's adoption of the protocol substrate, the establishment of a successor entity per `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md §"Succession"`, or a comparable event)

The expectation is irregularity. A long silence between issues is a sign that no material development has warranted publication, not a sign that publication has lapsed.

## §E Forward

The realignment work that prepared the reference implementation for this constitution is recorded in `docs/design/REALIGNMENT-TASK-GRAPH.md`.

- Phase 0 (federation hygiene of the protocol substrate, on which the reference implementation depends) closed at do-5 on 2026-05-05.

- Phase 3 (voice triage on the highest-traffic surfaces) closed at do-1 on 2026-05-05.

- Phase 1 (this constitution) closes with the publication of this issue.

- Phases 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, and 8 remain open.

Phase 0.5 hard launch gates remain open. The protocol substrate cannot ship as canonical reference implementation until those gates close. This issue, and the constitution it promulgates, is not gated by Phase 0.5; the constitution declares the

design commitments of the reference implementation independently of the launch event.

The constitution will, in time, be cited from outside this repository. This issue is the first such citation.

## §F Errata and amendments

*(none at first publication)*

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*This issue is the first entry in the public record. Subsequent issues append. The record begins.*

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PROMULGATED ARTIFACT · CONSTITUTION.md@v1.0.0

# Commons Design Constitution

Version: v1.0.0 Maintainer: Communiqué PBC (initial) Licence: at the recipient's choice, CC-BY-4.0 or Apache-2.0

## Preamble

This document is the design constitution of the reference implementation of the Commons protocol. It is published by Communiqué PBC as the maintainer of the reference implementation.

The protocol substrate — its cryptographic specifications, its on-chain governance, its trust-model accounting — is documented separately in `voter-protocol/specs/`. Peer

implementations of the protocol are welcome and are expected to publish their own design constitutions; they are not bound by this one.

This document binds the reference implementation. As of its publication, the protocol does not pass the walkaway test (see `voter-protocol/specs/TRUST-MODEL-AND-OPERATOR-INTEGRITY.md`). Several commitments below are observed in current shipping code; others are the direction of work and are labelled accordingly.

The constitution is amended through the procedure in §5. Editing without amendment — typos, formatting, broken links, errata of fact that do not change meaning — is permitted by the maintainer alone. Substantive change is amendment.

## §1 Substrate

The substrate is what holds plurality together.

### 1.1 The mathematics is the only authority

Where the protocol asserts a fact about identity, district, or delivery, that fact is a cryptographic verification anyone can re-run. It is not an assertion the maintainer asks to be trusted. Where verification is not yet possible, the assertion is honestly labelled as interpretive.

**OBSERVED**      the FROZEN domain strings, the three-tree membership proof, the district-nullifier mechanism, and the on-chain registry roots in `voter-protocol/specs/CRYPTOGRAPHY-SPEC.md`.

**ABSENT**        the rendered receipt does not yet surface its hash (`src/lib/components/template/TemplateModal.svelte` carries a TODO). The `Datum` and `Cite` primitives in `src/lib/design/` are defined but not yet propagated to all verifiable claims in the interface.

## 1.2 Federation by default

The substrate is independent of any single implementing organisation. The cryptographic strings, the on-chain registries, and the governance procedure operate without privileging the reference implementation. A peer implementation that follows the specifications correctly is compatible; the reference implementation has no editorial seat over the protocol.

**OBSERVED** the FROZEN strings carry the prefix `voter-protocol-*`, not `commons-*`. The licence model permits independent implementation. `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md` documents the federation expectation.

**ABSENT** no peer implementation yet exists. The transition gates in `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md` *Planned transition* require an independent peer to operate before the protocol can be considered federation-validated rather than federation-prepared.

## 1.3 Permanence over product cycles

The substrate is designed for thirty years. Where a decision is reversible, it is reversible cheaply. Where a decision is irreversible — the FROZEN domain strings, an on-chain registry root, a published constitutional amendment — the cost of getting it wrong is forever. The maintainer makes irreversible decisions sparingly and with explicit acknowledgement.

**OBSERVED** the FROZEN strings (migrated `commons-*` → `voter-protocol-*` pre-launch); the on-chain timelock structure documented in `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md` §"On-chain governance"; the convention of a signed deployment manifest binding deployed addresses to configured timelock values.

ABSENT

the on-chain anchoring of this constitution itself. Phase 6 of the realignment work commits the constitution's hash to a registry contract; until then, the canonical anchor is the first-publication sha256 in the issue masthead that promulgates the constitution.

## §2 Artifact

Every entry in the public record is an artifact.

### 2.1 Verifiable or honestly interpretive

Every visual element is one of two things: a verifiable claim — a count, a date, a hash, a district code — or an interpretation — a description, a rationale, a summary. The two registers are distinguishable typographically. Verifiable claims appear in JetBrains Mono with tabular numerals; interpretations appear in Satoshi.

This is the generative constraint of the Civic Proof design language, codified in this repository on 2026-04-13. The constitution names that language as the existing manifestation of this principle.

OBSERVED

the **Datum** and **Cite** primitives in `src/lib/design/` enforce the typographic distinction; the verification packet, the receipt, and the org specimen carry the constraint.

ABSENT

propagation across all surfaces. Many mid-traffic surfaces still mix registers without typographic distinction. Phase 8 of the realignment work addresses the gap.

### 2.2 Information has shape; express the shape

The five citizen dimensions — geography, time, identity, voice, engagement — are first-class design material. A count is not the same as a temporal rhythm; a tier is not the same as a composition. Each dimension has a primitive that expresses its shape: **Datum** for verifiable numerics, **Pulse** for temporal rhythm, **Ratio** for composition, **Rings** for tier or

depth, `Cite` for provenance, `Artifact` for bounded specimens, `EntityCluster` for proximity.

These are dimensions of *citizen* action. The dimensions an institution operates in — authority, jurisdiction, evidence — are documented in `voter-protocol/specs/`, where they belong. Naming this asymmetry honestly is part of the principle: the design constitution is built around the citizen-side of the civic contract because the reference implementation is the citizen-facing interface to the protocol.

**OBSERVED**      the seven primitives are defined in `src/lib/design/` and progressively replace ad-hoc Tailwind compositions.

**ABSENT**        display-scale typography for hero numbers and registry stamps. Email and PDF rendering preserve the dimensions only partially.

## 2.3 The cryptographic substrate is visible as registry marks

Hashes, nullifiers, Merkle roots, signatures, and version anchors appear in margins and footers as marks of the substrate, not behind copy. The reader of any artifact can find the cryptographic facts that hold the artifact together without leaving the artifact.

**OBSERVED**      the verification packet; the org specimen.

**ABSENT**        the homepage masthead, the receipt confirmation, the email and PDF exports. Phase 6 of the realignment work addresses the gap across the seven Audit B opportunities catalogued there.

## §3 Commons

The commons is how plurality coexists.

### 3.1 Plurality encoded, not curated

The substrate accepts entries from anyone meeting verification thresholds. Editorial discretion does not exclude legitimate entries. Where moderation is necessary, the



standards are published, the decisions are recorded, and the appeal path is open.

The two-layer Groq moderation pipeline rejects only injection attempts and content that fails the published safety standard. Legitimate political speech across the spectrum is accepted regardless of the maintainer's preferences. The five citizen dimensions encode plurality structurally; templates filter, locations filter, but no editorial axis filters.

**OBSERVED**      the moderation pipeline as published; the absence of editorial filtering on legitimate templates.

**ABSENT**        the appeal path is documented internally; the public-facing appeal artifact is forthcoming.

### 3.2 Decision-makers and constitutional moments share the substrate

A bill, a delivered message, a coalition founding, an amendment to this document, a debate transcript — these are entries in the same public record. The record does not privilege the institution over the citizen, or the citizen over the institution, or routine action over structural moment. The same primitives, the same cryptographic anchors, the same legibility expectations apply.

**OBSERVED**      the unified **DecisionMaker** entity in the data model; the verification packet routing citizen action to staffer-legible delivery.

**ABSENT**        the public DM page, the coalition founding charter artifact, the public debate index. Phase 5 of the realignment work addresses the gap.

### 3.3 Plain English

The voice register is plain English. Sentences a fourteen-year-old reads without help. No marketing superlatives. No emotional manipulation. No cypherpunk performance. Honest about what the system does and does not do.

This register is adopted by the reference implementation from this issue forward. It is not enforced on the substrate; peer implementations may choose differently. The supersession

of the prior register (`docs/design/voice.md` under "Direct. Specific. Institutional.") is recorded in the issue editorial note that promulgates this constitution.

**OBSERVED** the homepage masthead, the onboarding content, the receipt — per Phase 3 of the realignment work, closed 2026-05-05.

**ABSENT** further surfaces remain mixed-register. Phase 8 of the realignment work addresses the gap.

## §4 Open-protocol commitments

The reference implementation operates under the licence model, governance procedure, and trust model documented in `voter-protocol/`:

The protocol code is licensed under Apache-2.0 (`voter-protocol/LICENSE`).

The protocol specifications are licensed under the recipient's choice of CC-BY-4.0 or Apache-2.0 (`voter-protocol/LICENSE-specs`, `voter-protocol/LICENSE-CC-BY-4.0`).

The FROZEN cryptographic domain strings are committed and immutable post-launch (`voter-protocol/specs/CRYPTOGRAPHY-SPEC.md §0`).

Governance, succession, and conflict resolution operate per `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md`.

The walkaway-test accounting of what currently rests on operator integrity is in `voter-protocol/specs/TRUST-MODEL-AND-OPERATOR-INTEGRITY.md`.

The reference implementation does not extend or override these commitments through this constitution. Where this constitution and the protocol substrate disagree, the protocol substrate governs.

This document is licensed under the recipient's choice of CC-BY-4.0 or Apache-2.0, matching the protocol specifications.

## §5 Amendment

This constitution is amended through the spec-change process documented in `voter-protocol/specs/proposals/README.md`. Amendment is plural by construction.

An amendment proposal is admitted only when at least **two reviewers** concur in writing. At least **one** of those reviewers must be a person who is not a current or former Communiqué PBC employee, contractor, or fund recipient (the insider-conflict rule of `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md` §"Insider-conflict rule" applies). The independent reviewer is, in practice:

an independent security researcher; **or**

an operator of a deployed peer implementation as defined in `voter-protocol/GOVERNANCE.md` *Planned transition* (1); **or**

a maintainer of a peer civic-tech project who has reviewed the relevant section in writing.

The reviewers' written concurrence is recorded in the proposal's archival entry. PBC alone cannot amend this document.

When at least two peer implementations have adopted the protocol substrate per *Planned transition* (1), the threshold rises: amendment then requires **2-of-3 supermajority among adopting maintainers**. The constitution's amendment procedure scales with the protocol's federation.

Amendments take effect upon publication of a new Issue of the public record citing the amendment proposal's hash, the post-amendment hash of this document, and the date. Amendments do not retroactively change a document's first-publication hash; the full hash chain is preserved in the issue masthead in chronological order.

The maintainer's restraint is not the enforcement mechanism. The requirement of co-signers is.

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*Maintainer: Communiqué PBC. First publication promulgated by docs/record/vol-1/issue-1.md. Hash chain in that issue's masthead.*

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